

Deep Work — Mastery Quiz

Author: Cal Newport • 12 multiple-choice questions • Answer + explanation

Instructions: Choose the best answer before checking the answer and explanation.

1. *What is deep work?*

- A. Multitasking
- B. Focused work without distraction on demanding tasks
- C. Routine email
- D. Social networking

Correct answer: B

Why: Deep work is sustained concentration on cognitively demanding work.

2. *Why is deep work valuable?*

- A. It reduces all communication
- B. It creates high-value output and skill
- C. It requires no training
- D. It eliminates shallow work completely

Correct answer: B

Why: Concentration enables difficult tasks and rapid improvement.

3. *What is shallow work?*

- A. Work requiring maximum concentration
- B. Routine, logistical or easily replicated work
- C. Learning a difficult skill
- D. Strategic design

Correct answer: B

Why: Shallow work is often necessary but usually has lower cognitive value.

4. *What is attention residue?*

- A. Extra energy after exercise
- B. Attention left on a previous task after switching
- C. A meditation technique
- D. A type of deep work

Correct answer: B

Why: Task switching can leave part of your attention stuck on the previous task.

5. What should a deep-work ritual specify?

- A. Only the reward
- B. Where, when, what task and rules
- C. Your social media feed
- D. Only the deadline

Correct answer: B

Why: A ritual removes ambiguity and makes concentration repeatable.

6. Which behavior supports deep work?

- A. Constant notifications
- B. Frequent task switching
- C. Protected focus blocks
- D. Checking email every few minutes

Correct answer: C

Why: Protected blocks reduce interruptions and switching costs.

7. What does 'embrace boredom' mean?

- A. Stop working
- B. Train your brain not to require constant stimulation
- C. Avoid learning
- D. Work without goals

Correct answer: B

Why: Tolerance for boredom strengthens the ability to stay focused.

8. Why schedule shallow work?

- A. To make it infinite
- B. To prevent it from consuming your best attention
- C. To avoid all meetings
- D. To increase notifications

Correct answer: B

Why: Containing shallow tasks protects time for deeper work.

9. What is a shutdown ritual?

- A. Working all night
- B. Reviewing open loops and deliberately ending work
- C. Deleting all projects
- D. Avoiding planning

Correct answer: B

Why: A deliberate shutdown helps the mind disengage and recover.

10. Which is the best use of peak cognitive hours?

- A. Low-value admin
- B. Deep, high-value work
- C. Random browsing
- D. Notifications

Correct answer: B

Why: Your strongest attention should be allocated to the work that creates the most value.

11. What is a major enemy of deep work?

- A. Focus
- B. Distraction and context switching
- C. Planning
- D. Recovery

Correct answer: B

Why: Frequent switching prevents sustained concentration.

12. What is the overall principle of Deep Work?

- A. Do everything simultaneously
- B. Protect attention and concentrate intensely on important work
- C. Avoid difficult tasks
- D. Maximize meetings

Correct answer: B

Why: The book's central strategy is to deliberately cultivate concentration.

Scoring guide: 10–12 = strong mastery • 7–9 = good understanding • 4–6 = review the summary • 0–3
= reread the core concepts.